A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove

After three chapters of rebuke, Paul pleads as a father: he shows his affection for the Galatians and his authentic loyalty to them, laboring again until Christ is formed in them.

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · SellersBibleInstitute.com · used by permission

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Paul's affection and allegiance

Galatians 4:12–20 · The commentary's outline

I. Paul's Affection · 4:12–16

A — His plea
Become like me — free from the Law (12a)

B — His problem
He first came in physical weakness (12b–13)

C — Their approval
They received him as an angel of God (14–15)

D — His persuasion
Am I your enemy for telling the truth? (16)

II. Paul's Allegiance · 4:17–20

A — Artificial loyalty
The Judaizers court you for no good (17)

B1 — Certainty
Zeal in a good thing, always (18)

B2 — Compassion
“My little children” (19a)

B3–4 — Check · character
Until Christ is formed in you; I wish I were there (19b–20)

Then and now

Galatians 4:13–16 · Outline I.B–D

	Then — when Paul first came	Now — after the Judaizers
Paul's condition	A physical infirmity (ἀσθένεια) — v.13	The same Paul, telling the same truth
Their response	Did not despise or spit him out — v.14	“Have I become your enemy?” (ἐχθρός) — v.16
How they saw him	“As an angel of God, even as Christ Jesus”	As an opponent
Their blessing	Would have plucked out their own eyes for him — v.15	“What then was the blessing you enjoyed?”

I told you the truth. Now I am your enemy. Conclusion: I became your enemy because I told you the truth.

Two kinds of zeal

Galatians 4:17–18 · Outline II.A–B.1

	The Judaizers — artificial	Paul — authentic
The verb	ζηλοῦσιν — they zealously court you	ζηλοῦσθαι — zealous in a good thing
The aim	“for no good”	the truth and your good
The method	ἐκκλεῖσαι — shut you out from Paul	present or absent, the same
The result	“that you may be zealous for them”	that Christ be formed in you

Zeal is not the test. The truth, and the good of others, is.

“Until Christ is formed in you”

Galatians 4:19–20 · Outline II.B.2–4

1 Compassion · v.19a

τεκνία
“My little children” — a term of endearment

2 Cost · v.19b

ὠδίνω
“I labor in birth again” — a second labor for the same children

3 Goal · v.19c

μορφωθῇ
Christ formed in you — inward, essential form (cf. Rom 12:2)

4 Character · v.20

ἀποροῦμαι
“I have doubts about you” — perplexed, wishing to be present

Dare to discipline — and then hold them close. Truth with a steel fist, in a velvet glove.

Discuss and apply

Galatians 4:12–20 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How can Paul call his truth-telling the reason he became their “enemy” (v.16), and what does that warn us about?

2. What does it mean for Christ to be “formed” (μορφόω) in the Galatians, and how does that differ from simply believing correct doctrine?

Apply

Correct Like a Father, Labor Like a Mother
When you must say a hard true thing, pair it with a concrete word or act that shows the relationship survives it.

Aim at Formation, Not Attendance
Where you've managed behavior from the outside in, ask the Lord this week to do the inside-out work.

In one line: Speak the truth firmly, love tenderly, and labor until Christ is formed in others.